Habits

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/55994083.

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by chaosedalyn

Summary

Catra checked the time nervously, over and over again. The minutes passed rapidly fast as she procrastinated to speak to Adora.

There is still time to fix this. Right?

Eventually, one fight would be the last. One way or another.

Oneshot about how they may or may not break up.

Notes

This is the first time i wrote a oneshot in a foreign language. Please be nice lmao

Catra was taking a sip from her water bottle for the third time in a row as she was trying to keep herself busy. It was ultimately better than what she'd been doing before, which was drawing onto a random napkin she'd found behind the twenty cups neatly standing upside down in front of her. Somewhere far away, she almost noticed Adora talking to the customer who came in a minute ago, and Catra wondered if the middle-aged woman could feel the frozen air and if her lungs felt as tight as Catra's.

Everything seemed so loud and way too quiet at the same time, and she felt like the only way to get rid of this draining energy inside her body was by jumping straight out of the window and into traffic. Her attention was circling around one specific thought as she tried to form anything clear in her mind.

"Is it really over?"

Catra didn't dare to look at Adora while she was talking, not while she was ringing the register, and especially not while she threw the fakest "bye, have a nice day" Catra had ever heard at the woman who only came in to buy a cinnamon bun in peace.

Adora seemed so unbothered and far away, almost like a stranger. She most certainly felt like one.
Catra knew her a lot better than that though. That cold and distant look on Adora's face was only a desperate attempt to keep herself from collapsing right then and there. It felt surreal to think that Catra could ever be the one this face was looking at, or rather not looking at.

Last night had been rough.

"Are you going to say anything?" Adora was standing in the hallway of their apartment. Slowly but surely she slipped into her boots, taking a ridiculous amount of time to open them and taking even longer to tie them as if she didn't actually want to leave.

Catra hadn't answered. Everything in her screamed to just say something. Anything. But her body stopped listening to her a

good while ago.

She hated it.

If Catra was to describe hell to someone, it would be this very scenario.

It wasn't like she didn't know how much was on the line, but when she tried to talk about her feelings it was as if the engine turned off. A black screen right in front of her. All her thoughts became this swirl of words and sometimes it almost felt like she could form a sentence but she never managed to actually do it. There had been failed attempts of Catra anxiously trying to tell Adora about the sudden mutism she experienced, but eventually she'd given up on it.

She didn't even know what she was so afraid of. Adora had never in their lives reacted badly to literally any of the crap Catra had pulled, and yet she could for the life of her not untangle the knot in her vocal cords.

"I can't believe you're doing this again." Adora ripped her jacket off one of the hooks nailed into their door and put it on. She didn't look at Catra, she just stared at the wall in front of her, grinding her teeth.

"I don't understand why you can't talk to me. We've been there for each other our whole lives, does that mean nothing?" Adora's voice cracked as she fought back tears. Her voice grew louder with every word, she was almost shouting by the end of the sentence, "But at this point, I feel like you don't want me to be there anymore." Then Adora couldn't hold back her sobbing anymore and held onto the wall with one arm. Tears ran down her face uncontrollably.

"Why can't I ever be good enough for you?"

The blond girl sank on her knees as her body was trembling under her anguished cries. Hands clenched into fists layed out in front of her as her head came down to rest on them as if her body forced

her to calm down. Then her head shot up again and her piercing blue eyes shot through Catra's body like a thousand hot needles. "Why can't you take my love the way it comes and why does it feel like I have to fight to prove to you that it's real and not made up?"

Catra didn't dare to look at Adora as her heart was set ablaze in agony. The shadows of her fears crept over her shoulders and right into her brain.

But for a fraction of a second, she was taller than her shadows.

"Please stay." She managed to press through her lips.

Adora froze, as she was just opening the door. She didn't turn around, but she stood still for what felt like years to Catra but she could only be taller than her fears once and she knew she couldn't do it again.

All she had left to cling on was Adora and her magic ability to read Catra's mind, but the room felt tragically dark.

Adora closed her eyes and took a deep breath.

Then she left, and the door closed behind her with a sound Catra could only describe as mockery.

Now it was not only dark, but there was also a ghostly silence as the echo of Adora's footsteps faded into the night.

Catra started to cry. Her skin felt too tight and when she closed her eyes, everything started to spin and the entire planet was rumbling under the screams she let out into her pillow.

Two hours.

Two hours was a strange amount of time. A car ride, long enough to be uncomfortable but not long enough to bring sandwiches. A moment of panic when Catra had forgotten to finish an essay with only two hours left to hand it in. Not nearly enough time to clean

up the entire apartment before Adora would come home from work after she'd promised to clean up that day.

And eternity as Catra prayed for Adora to come back home, before she passed out of exhaustion and fell asleep on the couch. She was still in the same spot she'd already been sitting in when Adora left.

As Catra woke up the next morning, her gaze fell upon Adora's boots in the hallway. She looked at them for a long time, laying there like nothing had changed between them.

Except everything had changed.

With each passing moment, her uncertainty deepened. She wasn’t sure anymore if things had really changed or if this perfect little picture she made up in her head had never been real at all.

Maybe she was so caught up in her fantasy from the very beginning, that she never noticed Adora becoming an entirely different person, growing up while Catra stayed behind.

Maybe she noticed but selectively ignored it.

Or maybe Adora had just finally given up on her.

She couldn't really be mad at her, Catra was a mess. But all those big words out of Adora's mouth had over the years convinced Catra that she was telling the truth. That she was worth something and that she deserved someone who loved her.

And Adora had said it again yesterday, told her how she was loving and funny and the most loyal person she'd ever met and how Catra was eventually going to find someone who'd bring out the very best in her.

"It's just not gonna be me anymore."

Catra felt every single one of her hairs stand straight up at that.

She thought about everything they'd been through together and felt foolish about it. Wasn't that just what everybody said to try and make someone stay?

She could never begin understand how Adora had the strength to let go of her just like that. She knew it wasn't just like that, but it was easier to believe than to let her thoughts wander through all the times Adora must have thought about breaking up with her before she actually did it.

She had always been the strong one and Catra had always been the girl in her shadow.

Or at least she felt like it sometimes. She knew she was strong too, but Adora just always seemed to be one step ahead. Always knew what to do. Always had everything figured out. Always a solution for every problem coming right up.

Suddenly, all her kindness started to feel belittling to Catra. As if she was making fun of her.

Catra wasn't stupid. Deep down she knew her own insecurities were rising up like a wall of fire, blocking her path.

She knew that as hard as it was to hear, she wasn't good enough for Adora and it had only been a matter of time until reality caught up to her.

Not good enough in a sense that Adora needed someone to match her energy, not to steal it from her. Someone to hold her achievements high and not just see their own failure reflecting in them and someone who wouldn't hold Adora back out of fear she could outgrow Catra.

Someone who could love her as unconditionally as she seemed to be loving herself.

How could Catra ever match that? She knew she couldn't.

Neither now nor in the foreseeable future and by the time she was ready, all that's left would be ashes of a relentless inner conflict, a war she fought against herself with Adora trapped right in the middle of the crossfire.

There had been nights where she woke up horrified next to Adora sleeping peacefully and she had thought about just that.

How much longer until Adora realized that she was not good enough for her. That she was a burden to carry for herself and for Adora.

If only Catra had figured out sooner, that this irrational fear had the very power to turn her insecurities into reality.

She would've just forced herself to stop.

Tears wanted to well up in her eyes again, but there were none left. The haunting image of Adora leaving the apartment the day before manifested in front of her and she thought about how they were sitting next to each other without a clue what the night was going to end like just hours before.

"I'm just trying to help!" Adora's voice was soaked in annoyance, but she was still smiling, trying to untangle Catra's hair to get the blanket zipper out of it.

"Yeah, well I don't need your help." Catra snapped back while forcefully pulling the blanket out of her hair and suddenly, there was the first heavy silence of the evening.

The dense feeling of having screwed up crept through her veins and she felt hot like it was all piling up in her head specifically. Lately, those moments happened more frequently than Catra wanted to admit.

".. I know you don't need help. I'm not trying to help because you need it, I'm trying to help because I love you." Adora answered quietly, sounding like a kicked dog.

Her voice rang through Catra’s head over and over again, as she tried to figure out what she should've answered instead. She could've apologized and just been honest. Tell Adora that she knew. Tell her that it wasn't Adora's fault and how she was terrified to be dependent on someone and how she knew deep down that Adora just cared about her and that she enjoyed being cared for.

Instead, they argued.

Catra always felt stupid afterwards. She never knew why she said all those hurtful things. The only thing she knew for sure was that she couldn't take them back, even if she wanted to.

And she really wanted to.

It was hard for her to admit to having done something wrong.

Every time it happened, Adora fell silent and Catra wanted to punch herself and rip her skin off at once. She'd then try to talk herself out of it, wiggle her way around an actual apology and somewhere on the way, she made it a lot worse.

For a long time, Adora accepted it that way but at some point she told Catra to stop.

"I know this is hard for you, but I can't hold myself up assuming you're sorry. I can't let myself get hurt like that every time. You have to carry the consequences for the stuff you say." Adora was nearly whispering when she said that, Catra almost didn't hear her. Or didn't want to hear her.

She promised her to be better every single time.

Now she stared at Adora's boots in the hallway.
She'd come back.

Catra's heart sank a little, maybe she could still manage to save this mess. She swore to herself that she'd be honest with Adora

later this evening and started to think about all the things she'd tell her and how.

It was 7am when she last checked the time on her phone and in an hour Adora's shift would start. Which meant she should already be up by now since it was a 15- minute drive.

Catra debated on checking up on Adora to see if she overslept but decided against it.

Just when she considered Adora had taken the window instead of the door, she appeared in the hallway. And she looked terrible. Catra imagined Adora to be a mirrored image of herself as she hadn't really slept either. But there was something else on her face that Catra couldn't identify.

She didn't speak and she didn't look at her either as she put on her boots and with a final click, she closed the door behind her, sealing Catra in suffocating silence once again.
Catra had to swallow a big lump in her throat, staring at the door handle for a long time, as if she expected Adora to come back up and tell her everything was going to be fine, like always.
But the handle didn't move and neither did Catra.

Three hours passed fast and Catra had to get up and get ready for her shift to begin as well. Days where they had split shifts were the worst because whoever started first got to take the car, meaning she would have to take the bus or walk 45 minutes.

As soon as Catra sat in the bus, her thoughts ran wild. The memory of their argument replayed in her mind like a broken record, each word a sting in her heart. She couldn't shake the feeling of doom, of Adora walking away from their relationship for good. The bus rattled along its route, but Catra's world felt suspended in time, trapped in a bubble of anxiety. Her chest tightened with each passing moment.
As the bus came to a stop, Catra braced herself and got out. It would only be a couple more steps to the store but she felt like taking the next bus home and avoiding this whole thing forever.

When Catra stepped in, the air was heavy. Adora was standing behind the counter and looked up as she came through the front door, causing the tiny bell at the top to ring. "Hey." Adora offered, but she already looked down again when she spoke. "Hi," Catra answered simply. It came out weird, the tone was off and it sounded higher than she anticipated.

That was all. They stood next to each other for 4 hours without saying a word, playing pretend when a customer came in just to fall back into uncomfortable silence the second they left. And it didn't help that the day wasn't busy at all.

When Catra wasn't thinking about the way she said hi earlier, she caught herself wondering what Adora was thinking instead. It consumed her mind. She tried to come up with something to say, but her brain was a raging tornado and her ears rang, making it impossible to understand what the tornado could possibly have to say.

Everything seemed so loud and way too quiet at the same time, and she felt like the only way to get rid of this draining energy inside her body was by jumping straight out of the window and into traffic.

Her attention was circling around one specific thought as she tried to form anything clear in her mind.

"Is it really over?"

Catra grew increasingly nervous, as the end of Adoras shift came closer and she still hadn't said anything

Adora seemed so unbothered and far away, almost like a stranger. She most certainly felt like one.

That cold and distant look on Adora's face was only a desperate attempt to keep herself from collapsing right then and there. It felt surreal to think that Catra could ever be the one this face was looking at, or rather not looking at.

The clock struck 4 pm and by the time Catra figured out whether to say goodbye or not, Adora had already left without another word.

And by the time Catra came home from her shift, Adora had already left without another word.

She should've said goodbye.

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